

LOCAL NEWS

Spokane County Sheriff's Office deactivates license plate readers amid new state privacy law

Spokane County Sheriff's Office halts ALPR system use due to new Washington law focusing on privacy and data limits, raising concerns about community safety.

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SPOKANE COUNTY, Wash. — Spokane County Sheriff's Office (SCSO) announced Wednesday that it is being forced to deactivate automated license plate reader (ALPR) technology and associated systems due to a new state law that introduces [privacy protections and regulations in how ALPR data is accessed, stored and monitored](#).

On March 30, Governor Bob Ferguson signed Senate Bill 6002 into law. The bill was introduced in January after an October 2025 report by the [University of Washington Center for Human Rights](#) that showed federal agents were accessing ALPR, also known as Flock camera, data to pull over immigrants.

SCSO says that with the new regulations, it cannot keep using ALPRs without risking any violations of the new state law.

"This new state law imposes significant restrictions on ALPR systems, some of which were ill-considered, leading us to make this difficult decision. We are assessing how we continue using this crucial law enforcement tool inside the boundaries set by this new law. We did not make this choice lightly, and we believe the legislation as passed is making our community less safe," said SCSO in a press release.

The sheriff's office claims the law's "extremely strict and ill-considered regulations" open its employees to significant legal jeopardy, including the possibility that its staff and Deputies could be charged with a Gross Misdemeanor.

The text of the bill that was signed into law sets the following regulations:

1. Washington State law enforcement **will be able to use ALPRs** to investigate missing persons, stolen vehicles, gross misdemeanors, felonies and for parking or traffic-related purposes.
2. Law enforcement agencies are **prohibited** from using ALPRs for immigration investigation or enforcement purposes, on the premises or immediate surroundings to or from facilities that provide protected health care, or to track or otherwise monitor activity protected by the Washington state Constitution and the First Amendment to the United States Constitution.
3. Washington agencies can share access with other state agencies for permitted purposes.
4. Agencies must limit data retention to 21 days unless there is an exception, such as felony investigations, parking enforcement or traffic studies.
5. Law enforcement agencies must have a formal ALPR policy and submit annual usage reports by Dec. 1, 2027.

"I believe some in the legislature had good intentions, but unfortunately, it seems they did not completely understand ALPR technology, how effective it is, or the many ways it is used and not used," said Sheriff John Nowels. "These imposed restrictions have made it nearly impossible for law enforcement agencies across the State of Washington to continue using ALPR systems as currently designed and implemented, and that is unacceptable. I will continue to work with legislators and other law enforcement organizations to help find a reasonable solution to the unintended consequences that I believe make our community less safe."

